That set of people (of not more than twelve) was also bullying other yatris into performing menial tasks. Because my team's job was to create a positive atmosphere, we tried hard to ease these tensions by interjecting in our own individual capacities. After a point we had to escalate it to the party leadership, who asked us to make separate arrangements for an ever-widening group of civil society yatris. We were told to strictly not interfere, since that matter was seen as internal to civil society. But the differences and the ensuing conflicts became unmanageable upon the Yatra's departure from Rajasthan. That civil society group abruptly replaced long-standing yatris who had been walking since Kanyakumari with unknown participants. Almost forty to forty-five civil society yatris were summarily ousted, both from the WhatsApp group for their coordination and from the Yatra. I found this unfair and intervened to accommodate these people, even though that put more pressure on my team.

But that experience showed me the political maturity and sensitivity of the Congress party. The first impulse of the party leadership and ordinary Bharat yatris was to make everyone feel welcome in the Yatra. They didn't care about which party or organization or movement they belonged to. What mattered was that they were united in a shared fight for India. And therefore, the Congress party took everyone along. It is only because of this that no one left the Yatra. To me, this showed the importance of not becoming party to conflicts, something the Bharatiya Janata Party repeatedly does. This is why the Congress party is better suited to governance, because its instinct is to take everyone along. It is only because of this impulse that the Bharat Jodo Yatra transformed from a political journey into a people's movement.

The other important thing is that the Yatra was a moving pathshala (school) for thousands of Congresspersons. They had to undergo tremendous hurdles—physical and psychological—to finish the Yatra. We all learnt the importance of consistency and patience. But even more crucially, we were given a thorough understanding of the minutest problems in the smallest village from the southernmost to the northernmost points of India. Could any one of us have got such political education in so much